



High stakes: Edmund Lalrindika of East Bengal FC celebrates his opening goal of the match — one where defeat would have meant elimination from the title race. Instead, the draw keeps the contest alive until the final matchday. IFL MEDIA/AIFF

DERBY DAYS, TITLE DREAMS

The storied rivalry between East Bengal and Mohun Bagan lived up to its **rich legacy** as the two giants played out a hard-fought draw.

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Kolkata is a city that cherishes nostalgia. The yellow taxis, the heritage buildings and the cinematic nuance of the tramlines through jungles of dust and concrete — the city prefers smiling more at the past than at the present.

When the derby played out in the city on May 17, the emotion that came out strongest was this, about elements both on and off the field. The fans, the flags and the tension between *ghotis* and *bangals* — the match and its build-up had it all.

After kick-off, the drama spilled over onto the pitch: end-to-end action, East Bengal hitting the goalpost once, prompting contrasting sighs of relief and regret. Edmund

Lalrindika almost brought the roof down with the opening goal late in the second half, and then Jason Cummings restored parity to ensure none of the fans returned home with grim faces.

For fans, it was a joy to witness such a match, with over 62,000 in attendance and 90 minutes proving inadequate to separate the two rivals. For scribes, however, it evoked a whiff of Indian football nostalgia — the gritty calculations for a final